

New England

Massachusetts · New Hampshire · Rhode Island · Connecticut · Port: Boston

New England's thin, glacial soil and short summers ruled out the plantation agriculture that enriched the colonies farther south; its wheat barely feeds its own people. The region's wealth lay instead offshore and in its forests. Fishing fleets worked the North Atlantic banks and brought home far more cod than the colonies could consume, and dried, salted fish became almost a currency. Timber fed the shipyards of Boston and Newport, and the ships those yards launched are your greatest asset: seven merchant vessels, the largest fleet in the colonies.

That fleet defines New England's role. The region earned not only by selling goods but by moving everyone else's, which was called the carrying trade. The Southern Colonies and the West Indies own no ships, so every cargo they send must travel in someone else's hold; make sure it is yours, and charge for it.

The weakness sits inside your best export. Rhode Island's distilleries converted West Indian molasses into rum, which sold at every port, but the molasses had to be imported first. The game's rule reflects that cost: secure 2 molasses before each unit of rum you trade. When Parliament's Molasses Act of 1733 taxed molasses from the French islands, New England merchants largely ignored it and smuggled, an early sign of how colonists treated trade laws they disliked.

The tidy version of this story places slavery in the South and the Caribbean. The account books say otherwise. The molasses in New England rum was produced by enslaved people on sugar plantations, and New England's poorest-grade fish was shipped south as cheap food for them. Rhode Island merchants, many sailing from Newport, organized more slave-trading voyages than those of any other mainland colony: rum went to West Africa, captive Africans were forced aboard, and the ships carried them through the Middle Passage to be sold in the Caribbean. Enslaved people also lived and worked in Boston and Newport. The North's prosperity was built into the same system as the South's.

You have: fish, whale oil, lumber, rum, and 7 ships.

WORDS TO KNOW

Distillery

A works converting molasses to rum; the New England distilleries bound the northern colonies into the sugar economy and its slave trade.

Molasses

Sugar refining's by-product and rum's precursor; its price differential with sugar made it the West Indies' volume export to the northern colonies.

Enslaved / Slavery

Chattel slavery: the legal status of being owned as property, lifelong and inherited through the mother, which colonial law attached to African descent.

Enslaved names something done to people by others, where slave can sound like an identity; historians use it to keep both the people and those responsible in view.

The Middle Passage

The middle leg of the Atlantic triangle, in which captive Africans were shipped to the Americas. About 12.5 million people were forced aboard slave ships over the whole history of the trade, and nearly 2 million died at sea. Each was a person with a name, a family, and a home, which the ships' records almost never kept. The name itself describes the voyage from the traders' side: for the people aboard it was not the middle of anything, but the violent break from everything they knew.

Export / Import

The two directions of trade; mercantilism sought to maximize exports over imports at the national level, the favorable balance of trade.

Raw Materials

Unprocessed natural commodities; under mercantilism, the colonial side of the exchange, exported cheap and returned dear as manufactures.

Naval Stores

Pine-derived tar, pitch, and resin essential to caulking and rigging wooden vessels; a strategic commodity for any naval power.

NEW ENGLAND IN THE GAME

Starts with 7 Dried Fish, 3 Whale Oil, 5 Lumber, 6 Rum

Ships Owns 7 ships.

Middle Colonies

New York · New Jersey · Pennsylvania · Delaware · Port: Philadelphia

The Middle Colonies were the breadbasket of British America: harvests of wheat and corn far exceeded what the colonists consumed, and the surplus left Philadelphia and New York as grain, flour, and salted meat. Add cattle, abundant timber, and a fur trade with Native American nations whose pelts commanded high prices in London, and higher still on the European continent, though the Navigation Acts required that furs pass through England first.

The region owns a small merchant fleet of 2 ships, enough to trade independently but not lavishly. That is the first limit on your strategy. The second is the nature of your goods: useful to everyone, but bulky and cheap per shipload. Your advantage is necessity; your challenge is value.

The sophisticated play is indirect. Sugar commands extraordinary prices in England. Convert your wheat into West Indian sugar, then convert that sugar into English manufactures, and you have multiplied the value of your harvest twice.

The tidy version calls this region the colonies' pantry and stops there. Follow the flour, though, and it leads to the cane fields. Sugar islands devoted so much land to cane that they imported their food, so Middle Colonies grain fed the enslaved people forced to work there, and colonial lumber and livestock built and powered the sugar mills. Those people had survived the Middle Passage, the forced crossing of the Atlantic that killed many of the captives packed below deck. Slavery was also part of daily life here. New York City had one of the largest enslaved populations of any colonial city, and enslaved people worked its docks and households; Pennsylvania's Quaker merchants held enslaved people as well. Yet it was also in Pennsylvania, in 1688, that a small group of Germantown Quakers wrote one of the first protests against slavery in the colonies, which shows that people at the time could see the wrong clearly.

You have: wheat and grains, lumber, cattle, furs, and 2 ships.

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Cash Crop

A crop cultivated primarily for market exchange; the plantation colonies' commitment to cash crops produced wealth, import-dependence, and the demand for enslaved labor.

Monopoly

Exclusive control over a commodity or market, conferring the power to set terms; identify your own monopolies and price them accordingly.

MIDDLE COLONIES IN THE GAME

Starts with 7 Wheat & Grains, 7 Lumber, 5 Cattle, 7 Furs

Ships Owns 2 ships.

Southern Colonies

Maryland · Virginia · N. Carolina · S. Carolina · Georgia · Port: Charleston

The South is rich in goods and poor in transport. Tobacco dominates, grown in such quantity that the English market is glutted: under heavy duties the price collapsed to about a penny a pound, while buyers on the European continent who would pay far more were walled off by the Navigation Acts. South Carolina adds rice, silk, and indigo, a dye so prized by English cloth-makers that Parliament paid a bounty for it from 1748. North Carolina supplies naval stores, without which no shipyard in England or New England can operate. Maryland contributes fish, and the backcountry fur trade rounds out eight distinct goods, the most diverse inventory in the game.

And none of it moves. The South owns no merchant ships; Charleston and Savannah are warehouses waiting for other people's vessels. Every negotiation therefore carries a freight question: who carries the cargo, and at what price? Hire a hull from New England, the Middle Colonies, or England, or trade for a ship outright, but solve that first, because unsold tobacco wins nothing.

The dependence ran deep enough that planters described it as a kind of bondage. Thomas Jefferson wrote that Virginia's tobacco growers fell so far into debt to British merchants that they became "a species of property, annexed to certain mercantile houses in London" (Thomas Jefferson, 1786). The phrase is striking because the men who used it held people as actual property. The tobacco, rice, and indigo were planted and harvested by enslaved people, many of them survivors of the Middle Passage; more captive Africans entered through Charleston than through any other mainland port. The tidy version leaves out their knowledge and their resistance. Carolina planters sought out captives from the rice-growing regions of West Africa for their skill. And in 1739, enslaved people near the Stono River rose up and marched toward Spanish Florida, which had promised freedom to those who escaped.

You have: tobacco, rice, naval stores, fish, lumber, furs, silk, indigo. No ships.

WORDS TO KNOW

Cash Crop

A crop cultivated primarily for market exchange; the plantation colonies' commitment to cash crops produced wealth, import-dependence, and the demand for enslaved labor.

Indigo

A plant-derived blue dyestuff cultivated by enslaved people in the Lower South; so prized by the English textile industry that Parliament paid a bounty for it.

Naval Stores

Pine-derived tar, pitch, and resin essential to caulking and rigging wooden vessels; a strategic commodity for any naval power.

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Duty

An import tax; under the Navigation Acts, a fiscal instrument by which the Crown captured revenue from colonial commerce.

Mercantilism

An economic doctrine holding that national power derives from a favorable balance of trade, under which colonies exist to supply raw materials to, and consume the manufactures of, the imperial center.

SOUTHERN COLONIES IN THE GAME

Starts with 7 Tobacco, 4 Rice, 5 Naval Stores, 1 Dried Fish, 4 Lumber, 2 Furs, 2 Silk, 3 Indigo

Ships None. This region has to hire a ship from another region.

West Indies

Jamaica · Barbados · Antigua · St. Kitts · Port: Kingston

The West Indies were the engine of the Atlantic economy. Sugar commanded prices no mainland crop could touch, and planters devoted so much land to cane that they imported even their food rather than spare an acre. Molasses, sugar's by-product, fed New England's distilleries; citrus, a sideline, helped keep sailors healthy at sea. That concentration is your biggest advantage: everyone wants what you have.

It is also your biggest challenge. You need nearly everything else, and you own no ships to fetch it. You must hire New England, Middle Colony, or English vessels, or trade for a ship of your own. French, Spanish, and Dutch islands undercut your prices, so English colonial loyalty is your lifeline; planters lobbied Parliament for the Molasses Act of 1733 to tax their rivals' molasses.

That profit was extracted through slavery on an industrial scale. Enslaved Africans, forcibly transported through the Middle Passage, performed the dangerous labor of the cane fields and boiling houses, and by the mid-1700s made up about nine in ten of Jamaica's people. Olaudah Equiano, carried across the Atlantic as a boy, remembered the voyage this way: "I now wished for the last friend, death, to relieve me" (Olaudah Equiano, *The Interesting Narrative*, 1789).

The tidy version counts the sugar and stops. What it leaves out is the arithmetic of the plantations themselves. Sugar work was so deadly that on many islands deaths outnumbered births for generations, and planters chose to keep buying newly captured Africans rather than change how they worked people. That is why the Caribbean took a far larger share of the slave trade than mainland North America. Enslaved people resisted, from daily refusals to open revolt; in Jamaica, communities of escaped people called Maroons fought the British until a treaty in 1739 recognized their freedom. The sugar and molasses you move for points in this game were the products of that suffering and that struggle.

You have: sugar, molasses, citrus fruit. No ships.

WORDS TO KNOW

Molasses

Sugar refining's by-product and rum's precursor; its price differential with sugar made it the West Indies' volume export to the northern colonies.

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WEST INDIES IN THE GAME

Starts with 4 Citrus Fruit, 9 Sugar, 15 Molasses

Ships None. This region has to hire a ship from another region.

England

The Mother Country · Port: London

You represent England's merchants and the government behind them, operating the machinery of mercantilism: the doctrine that colonies exist to enrich the Mother Country. The law is your first asset. The Navigation Acts, beginning in 1651, confined colonial trade to English ships and routed the most valuable colonial goods through England, so almost every musket, printed book, bolt of cloth, and fine chair in America passes through your hands at your prices. Manufactured goods sell dear; raw materials buy cheap; the difference is empire.

Your second asset is the fleet: 8 merchant ships, the most in the game, and shipless regions will pay for space in your holds. Parliament supplies the third: duties levied by chance cards usually fall into your stores.

Yet the empire runs on colonial goods, and that is your challenge. The fleet consumes the products of colonial forests; London buyers demand colonial cash crops; even food must come in. Your needs list is the longest in the game, and almost all of it is raw materials only the colonies supply. Dominance is not self-sufficiency.

Even at the time, critics saw the design plainly. Adam Smith wrote: “To found a great empire for the sole purpose of raising up a people of customers, may at first sight appear a project fit only for a nation of shopkeepers. It is, however, a project altogether unfit for a nation of shopkeepers; but extremely fit for a nation whose government is influenced by shopkeepers.” (Adam Smith, *The Wealth of Nations*, 1776).

What the tidy version of mercantilism leaves out is the cargo on the second leg. In the 1700s British ships carried more captive Africans across the Atlantic than those of any other nation. Cloth, guns, and metal goods went to West Africa; captives were forced through the Middle Passage and sold into slavery; sugar and tobacco grown by enslaved people came home. Liverpool and Bristol built their docks and fortunes on that circuit.

You have: guns, gunpowder, clothing, fine furniture, tools, books, silver, and 8 ships.

WORDS TO KNOW

Mother Country

The imperial metropole; the legal and economic center to which colonial trade was subordinated.

Manufactured Goods

Finished commodities whose production England monopolized; their price premium over raw materials was the engine of mercantilist profit.

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ENGLAND IN THE GAME

Starts with 4 Guns, 4 Gunpowder, 2 Clothing, 2 Fine Furniture, 3 Tools, 3 Books, 2 Silver

Ships Owns 8 ships.